they believed would be another derisory attempt against their fortress of legend but Akbar was not just another attacker and his dreams were far greater than just the subjugation of a spiky neighbour.

Once the Mughal camp had been pitched, Akbar got onto his horse and rode around the entire circumference of the fortress, accompanied by the surveyors who always travelled with the army. He had the distances carefully assessed and then ordered battle stations assigned and entrenchments dug. According to historian de la Garza, as a weapon, ‘the shovel was nearly as important as the musket’. The soldiers now dug slit trenches and constructed sandbag barricades, and individual fighting holes which were soon manned by reinforcements that arrived every day. Within a month, the entire fortress was ringed by the besiegers, while three main batteries were stationed around it. The Mughal troops had built a circumvallation, a line of fortifications around the fortress including not only ‘zigzag trenches and sunken gun emplacements but also sirkob, or siege towers’. All the while, individual amirs in shows of braggadocio, charged at the fortress, shooting their muskets from their galloping horses at the defending soldiers. But the besieged soldiers within the fort were far from defenceless. From behind the safety of Chittor’s stone walls, snipers hit the Mughal forces with deadly accuracy. The Rajput soldiers used the crossbow, which was not as advanced as the Mughal composite bow but was easy to use and especially effective when used from a prone position. They also had muskets, which a group of crack shots, led by their chief musketeer, Ismail, used from within Chittor’s walls to great effect. Meanwhile, Akbar was unable to deploy his most deadly weapon, the mounted archers. As proud descendants of Central Asian Timurid warlords, the most skilled and versatile element of the Mughal army, the one favoured by the elite, was the horse archer, who combined deadly accuracy with the composite bow with speed of movement. But in the siege conditions of Chittor, Mughal artillery and arrows sailed harmlessly over the fort walls so Akbar decided to engineer sabats, covered trenches, to bring his fierce firepower closer to the walls of the fort.

Raja Todar Mal and Qasim Khan supervised the construction of the sabats and 5,000 carpenters, stonecutters, blacksmiths, excavators, earthworkers, and shovelmen set to work digging trenches with walls and roofs of wood, canvas, and leather so that sappers and elephants could approach the walls of the fort to place their heavy guns. In the pouring rain,